Lesson 06: Coping: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 2.1: Discussion; 2.2: Listening-5 Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms You Shouldn't Ignore; 2.3: Reading-Coping Mechanisms; 16.2: Chapter 2 (audio transcript).

In this lesson

You will think about how you deal with stress, watch a Psych2Go video about five unhealthy coping mechanisms, and read the article "Coping Mechanisms". You will practise finding the central idea of a text, working out the meaning of a word from context, and writing one-sentence definitions of psychology terms.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Follow a short video organized as a numbered list and answer detail questions about it.
- Explain the difference between adaptive and maladaptive coping mechanisms, with examples.
- Find the central idea of an article and the quotation that supports it.
- Work out the meaning of a word from its context.
- Define a psychology term in one clear sentence.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
coping mechanism	a method that a person uses to deal with stress or conflict	Psychologists call these "coping mechanisms."
adaptive	positive and helpful in the long term	Problem-solving is an adaptive coping mechanism.
maladaptive	negative; helpful in the short term but harmful in the long term	Maladaptive coping mechanisms may only make stress levels rise in the long run.
alleviate	make stress or pain less strong	Adaptive coping mechanisms are positive ways people alleviate stress.
diminish	make smaller or weaker	Do you have strategies to diminish your stress?
anticipation	preparing for a difficult challenge by imagining what it will be like	Anticipation is a way to reduce the stress of a difficult challenge.
denial	the refusal to accept truth or fact	People are said to be "in denial" when they act as if the problem doesn't exist.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
projection	blaming someone else for an emotion that you feel is unacceptable	A husband who feels angry may accuse his wife of being the angry one.
dissociation	trying to "disconnect" from a traumatic or stressful event	A person who has dissociative behavior may even invent a new imaginary world.
toxic positivity	trying to look positive at all times, even when you are not in a good mood	It comes from a place of denial, invalidation or minimization.
repress (feelings)	push feelings down and not show them	Are you repressing your feelings because you think that no one cares?
isolate yourself	stay away from other people	Socially isolating yourself is not a healthy habit.
catastrophize	imagine that something is the worst possible thing	A tool to help overcome this need to catastrophize is to think of the five worst outcomes.
resilience	the ability to recover from difficult times	Fostering your mental resilience can be helpful when times of stress do arise.

Rules and explanations

How the video is organized

- The video starts with a short introduction about healthy and unhealthy ways of coping.
- Then it gives a numbered list: "Number one, ...", "Number two, ...". Each part describes the problem and then suggests something healthier.
- Take notes in three columns: the mechanism, why it is unhealthy, what to do instead.

How the reading is organized

- Paragraphs 1-2: a definition of "coping mechanism" and two categories.
- "Adaptive Coping Mechanisms" (paragraphs 3-7): Anticipation, Seeking Support, Problem-Solving, Humor.
- "Maladaptive Coping Mechanisms" (paragraphs 8-11): Denial, Projection, Dissociation.
- Paragraph 12: advice for dealing with stress.
- Headings like these show you the plan of a text before you read it. Look at them first.

Defining and classifying terms

Psychology texts define a term in one sentence, then explain it or give an example. The reading uses these patterns:

- Term + is + a/the + general word + that/to ...: "A coping mechanism is a method that a person uses to deal with stress or conflict." "Denial is the refusal to accept truth or fact."
- Term + is + a way to + verb: "Anticipation is a way to reduce the stress of a difficult challenge ..."

- Classifying: "Psychologists categorize coping mechanisms into two different categories: adaptive coping mechanisms and maladaptive coping mechanisms."
- Giving an example: "For example, a husband who feels angry at his wife may accuse her of being the angry one ..."

Questions about a whole text and about words

- **Central idea (Part A):** the main point of the whole text. Test each option: is all of it in the text, and is it true for the whole text?
- **Vocabulary in context:** "What does X mean as it is used in paragraph 9?" A word can have several meanings. Choose the meaning that fits this sentence, and look for a clue in the same paragraph. Part B asks you for that clue.
- **Author's purpose:** look at the verb in each option (inform, advise, explain, provide a history). Which one describes the whole text?

Grammar to notice (Lesson 07)

- -ing words used as nouns (gerunds): "Thinking about tragic events helps people prepare for unforeseen difficult circumstances."
- to + verb (infinitives): "Anticipation is a way to reduce the stress of a difficult challenge."

Practice

Before you start: read the discussion questions in the Writing task and think about your answers for two minutes.

Exercise 1. Listening comprehension. Watch "5 Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms You Shouldn't Ignore" (see Watch online) first, without the transcript. Answer the questions. Then watch again. Read the transcript at the end of the lesson material only after you have answered.

1. Which of the following mechanisms is an unhealthy way to deal with stress? a) exercise b) listening to music c) staying positive about all situations
2. Which of the following is not an example of toxic positivity? a) "Don't think about it, be positive!" b) "Everything will work out in the end." c) "If I can do it, so can you." d) "It could be worse." e) "It's OK to feel bad sometimes."
3. What is a healthy way to deal with social anxiety? a) Force yourself to attend parties. b) Isolate in your room. c) Invite someone you feel comfortable with to accompany you in social situations. d) Use social media to make friends.
4. The fourth unhealthy coping mechanism relates to repressing emotions. However, it is possible to overreact. Which strategy to minimize emotion was not provided? a) yelling into a pillow b) meditating c) dancing d) talking on the phone

Exercise 2. Reading comprehension. Read "Coping Mechanisms" in the lesson material (12 paragraphs). Then answer.

1. PART A: Which of the following statements best expresses a central idea of the text? a) The best way to cope with stress is to remain positive and ignore all negative emotions, rather than dwell on stressful situations. b) Studying one's dreams is a great adaptive coping mechanism because it prompts one to reflect on their life choices. c) All adaptive coping mechanisms become maladaptive if utilized and relied on too frequently. d) People use different methods to deal with stress, which can produce positive and negative consequences depending on how one chooses to cope.
2. PART B: Which quote from the text best supports the answer to Part A? a) "People have many different strategies for dealing with stressful situations — some helpful, and some not so helpful." (Paragraph 1) b) "when humor is overused as a coping mechanism, it can lead to denial or avoidance" (Paragraph 7) c) "Sigmund Freud, the famous psychoanalyst who was the first person to study the significance of dreams, is credited with popularizing the idea of denial." (Paragraph 9) d) "a person who has dissociative behavior may even invent a new imaginary world where they do not have to face an uncomfortable feeling or memory." (Paragraph 11)
3. PART A: What does "primitive" mean as it is used in paragraph 9? a) uncivilized b) old-fashioned c) instinctive d) foolish
4. PART B: Which phrase from paragraph 9 best supports the answer to Part A? a) "to reject its existence" b) "despite overwhelming evidence" c) "proving the contrary" d) "develop in early childhood"
5. What is the author's primary purpose in this text? a) to inform the reader about various adaptive and maladaptive coping mechanisms b) to advise the reader on how to deal with specific stressful situations c) to explain how stress can harm someone mentally, emotionally, and physically d) to provide a history of psychology and its everyday benefits

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me five questions about the video '5 Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms You Shouldn't Ignore'. Then ask me the question at the end of the video: which of these mechanisms do I relate to most?"
- "Say the name of a coping mechanism from the reading. I will define it in one sentence (It is a ... that ...) and give an example. Correct my definition."
- "Describe a stressful situation for a university student. I will suggest an adaptive coping mechanism and explain why it is better than a maladaptive one."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 2. Ask me to show you the clue words for question 3 in paragraph 9."

Read aloud

1. A coping mechanism is a method that a person uses to deal with stress or conflict.
2. Psychologists categorize coping mechanisms into two different categories.
3. Denial is the refusal to accept truth or fact.
4. Thinking about tragic events helps people prepare for unforeseen difficult circumstances.
5. It's all right to be angry, jealous, annoyed /d/ or deeply upset about things.

6. Word stress: a·DAP·tive, an·tic·i·PA·tion, de·NI·al, pro·JEC·tion, dis·so·ci·A·tion, al·LE·vi·ate, di·MIN·ish.

Writing task

Discussion post. Write a post of 150 to 200 words that answers these questions:

- What do you do when you are stressed? Do you have strategies to diminish your stress?
- What situations make you stressed?

Use at least three terms from the reading (for example: adaptive, maladaptive, anticipation, seeking support, problem-solving, humor, denial), and define one of them in one sentence.

Then ask your tutor: "Write two short posts as two classmates who answered the same questions." Reply to each post in 2-3 sentences: point out a similarity or a difference, ask a clarifying question, or give your opinion on one of their points.

Checklist:

- I answered all the questions.
- I used the simple present for habits (When I am stressed, I usually ...), with -s after he/she/it.
- I used at least three terms from the reading correctly.
- I defined one term with the pattern "X is a ... that ...".
- I gave a reason or an example for each strategy.
- I connected my ideas with words like because, so and for example.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- "5 Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms You Shouldn't Ignore" (Psych2Go): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PyIyxeMXKeg

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. c) staying positive about all situations (book). This is "forced positivity", number one in the video. Going to the gym and singing along to music are "good and healthy".
2. e) "It's OK to feel bad sometimes." (book). The video says: "It's all right to be angry, jealous, annoyed or deeply upset about things."
3. c) (book). The video says: "try going to an event with someone you know".
4. d) talking on the phone (book). The video mentions meditating, yelling into a pillow, dancing and working out.

Exercise 2

1. d) (book). The text describes helpful (adaptive) and unhelpful (maladaptive) ways of coping.
2. a) (book). "some helpful, and some not so helpful" matches "positive and negative consequences".
3. c) instinctive (book).
4. d) "develop in early childhood" (book). Something that babies develop is not learned from experience: it is instinctive.
5. a) (book).

My notes